Friends Afar

The First Secretary made his first sally out of the East European socialist stronghold when, in answer to an invitation from Cuba's Fidel Castro, he led a high-level delegation to Havana in February 1974.

In the excitement of the moment, Honecker displayed a touch of the theatricals by sending a telegram to British Prime Minister Edward Heath while flying over the United Kingdom. He wrote:

Your Excellency, allow me to convey to you and to the British people my best wishes as I fly over the territory of your country on my way to the Republic of Cuba. I should like to combine this wish with the hope that the relations between the German Democratic Republic and the United Kingdom may develop for the benefit and happiness of our peoples and in the interests of peace, security and cooperation in Europe.

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Eight hours later, the theatricals continued when, squinting against the bright sunlight, the German delegation arrived to a celebrity welcome in Havana, where cheers of 'Long Live the First Secretary' could be heard as they disembarked from a gleaming Interflug jetliner. Across the Cuban capital, workers had been given time off in order to line the streets and wave GDR flags. 'Now,' Honecker recounted, 'Castro, together with his vivacious people, welcomed our delegation on the island of freedom.'2 Dressed not in a suit but in a white jacket and a Canotier, Honecker played the part of the exultant guest, smiling deeply before the public and shaking